obvious relation to the Cuban crisis" or, alternatively, "on a strictly secret basis with the Soviets." He added that "stipulation of secrecy might not be too convincing since would involve good faith of Soviets who would always have option to reveal to detriment of US Turkish relations." No one knew better than Kennedy that Khrushchev, who had lied about the missiles only a few weeks earlier, was not to be trusted, but he had no choice but to put his trust in that man again.[9]

"The moment Dean Rusk made his suggestion it became apparent to all of us that we should agree," remembered Bundy. But the secrecy provision of the deal required silence not only from Khrushchev but also from those making the decision on the American side. "Concerned as we all were by the cost of a public bargain struck under pressure at the apparent expense of the Turks, and aware as we were from the day's discussions that for some, even in our closest councils, even this unilateral private assurance might appear to betray an ally, we agreed without hesitation that none not in the room was to be informed of this additional message," recalled Bundy.[10]

The "additional message" mentioned by Bundy was in fact the main message that Robert Kennedy had to deliver and, shockingly, it would be kept secret from the rest of ExCom, including Vice President Johnson and the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, General Taylor, as well as the head of the CIA, John McCone. Rusk, the alleged author of the formula accepted by the others, later underplayed his role in the conspiracy and stressed that he had been adamant in making sure that the removal of the missiles from Turkey was not included in the Cuban deal.

"I suggested that since the Jupiters in Turkey were coming out in any event, we should inform the Russians of this so that this irrelevant question would not complicate the solution of the missile sites in Cuba," wrote Rusk later. "We agreed that Bobby should inform Ambassador Dobrynin orally. Shortly after we returned to our offices, I telephoned Bobby to underline that he should pass this along to Dobrynin only as information, not a public pledge. Bobby told me that he was then sitting with Dobrynin and had already talked with him. Bobby later told me that Dobrynin called this message 'very important information.' " Rusk's account allowed for the possibility that it was Robert Kennedy, and not he, who crossed the barely perceptible line between the reciprocal deal and the unrelated removal of